

Vike Marketing — 12-Month Growth Roadmap (First Client → Premium Positioning)

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Prepared: 2026-09-21 | **Companion document:** [06-growth-and-seo.md](#) (SEO/social/authority detail behind every milestone below) | **Founder capacity:** ~16 hrs/week solo throughout unless stated otherwise

Honesty framing up front: SEO and authority-building are slow, compounding channels — real organic rankings typically take 4-12 months even with consistent execution, and review-based awards require reviews that don't exist yet. This roadmap does **not** promise fast SEO wins or a large client roster by month 12. It promises a realistic sequence: fix the foundation, generate proof, then convert that proof into compounding organic/authority assets, while client acquisition itself continues to lean on the outbound-first approach detailed in [04-first-client-plan.md](#). Milestones below are deliberately conservative and cross-referenced to file 1's sections in brackets, e.g. [\[\\$1.6\]](#).

Q1 (Months 1-3): Fix the Foundation, Generate the First Proof

Theme: technical SEO fixes + first reviews + light, consistent content and social cadence. This quarter is about making Vike *findable and credible*, not about ranking for anything yet.

Milestones

- **[] Site indexed by Google** — SSL re-verified, Search Console property verified, sitemap submitted, robots.txt/noindex leaks checked and fixed, homepage + service pages manually submitted for indexing [\[\\$1.6\]](#). **This is the single most important Q1 technical outcome** — nothing else in SEO works until it's done.
- **[] Organization + LocalBusiness schema live** on the homepage, addressing the brand-collision risk with [sameAs](#) links to LinkedIn/GBP/Clutch [\[\\$0, \\$1.6\]](#).
- **[] Pricing page rebuilt** as its own indexable URL with FAQ schema [\[\\$1.3, \\$1.6\]](#).
- **[] 3-5 real Google reviews collected** from Junior School, Mary, and Alex (direct-link asks, personalized) — the top trust priority of the entire plan [\[\\$1.5, \\$3.1\]](#).

- [] **GBP category audited and corrected** if a mismatch is found; weekly GBP posts started [§1.5] .
- [] **2 SEO articles + 2 local-niche pages published** per the Q1 portion of the content calendar (cost-guide article, pricing/no-contract page, preschool local page started) [§1.4] .
- [] **LinkedIn (3x/week) and Instagram (2x/week) cadence started**, using content pillars from §2.2 — includes at least 3 of the 12 ready-to-use post ideas, prioritizing the real testimonial stories [§2.3, §2.4, §2.5] .
- [] **5-10 directory backlinks secured** (GoodFirms, DesignRush, Sortlist, Clutch) [§1.7] .
- [] Client count: continues per file 04's 30/60/90-day plan (outbound-led, not SEO-led — SEO cannot produce leads yet at this stage since the site isn't indexed until partway through the quarter).

Honest Q1 expectation: zero meaningful organic rankings by month 3 — that's normal and expected, not a failure. The goal is a technically clean, indexed, review-backed foundation that months 4+ can compound on.

Q2 (Months 4-6): Build the Content Engine, Start Earning Authority Signals

Theme: consistent content production, first local rankings appear for low-competition long-tail terms, first outside recognition attempts begin.

Milestones

- [] **First indexed rankings appear for long-tail, low-competition local terms** (e.g., Lviv preschool/dental niche pages) — realistic given 4-6 months of indexing + content + the direct proof-point advantage from Junior School [§1.2 local table] . **Not** expecting Ireland/Netherlands competitive terms to rank yet — those are medium-high difficulty and take longer [§1.2] .
- [] **Dental clinic Lviv landing page live**, completing the initial local-niche page set [§1.4] .
- [] **"Google Ads vs Meta Ads" comparison piece published** and actively used as LinkedIn/Instagram content and light outreach for backlinks (share with 5-10 relevant sites/communities) [§1.4, §1.7] .
- [] **5-8 real Google reviews total**, first Clutch review requested from at least one client.
- [] **First case-study-style page live** (not a "case study" in the formal metrics-heavy sense — a well-written client story page per §2.5, now with client-approved quotes and, where permitted, names/logos).
- [] **Apply to Expertise.com / GoodFirms category listings** (lower-barrier than Clutch awards) [§3.1] .
- [] **First guest post or HARO-style placement secured** (1 piece, realistically) [§1.7, §3.2] .
- [] **UGC creator relationship formalized enough to produce 2-3 Reels** (founder interview format, one light skit) — still framed honestly as informal/part-time collaboration, not a "team," until it's actually formalized [§2.6] .

- [] **Lviv IT Cluster membership/partnership explored** — at minimum, attend one event or join the community platform [§3.3] .
- [] Client count and revenue: tracked against file 04's targets; SEO/social are now a secondary lead source alongside continued outbound, not yet a primary one.

Honest Q2 expectation: Vike starts showing up for a handful of specific, low-competition local searches. Ireland/Netherlands competitive terms remain out of reach. This is the quarter reviews and case-study content start doing real conversion work in sales conversations, even before they move rankings much.

Q3 (Months 7-9): Compound the Proof, Push Into Ireland/Netherlands SEO

Theme: with 6+ months of reviews, content, and backlinks compounding, shift more SEO/content effort toward the strategic Ireland/Netherlands market, where competition is tougher but the budget-fit opportunity is largest.

Milestones

- [] **"Month-to-month vs contract agencies" and remaining Q3 content pieces published**, explicitly targeting Ireland/Netherlands search intent (no-contract differentiation angle) [§1.4] .
- [] **First non-trivial organic traffic to an Ireland/Netherlands-targeted page** — realistic goal is measurable-but-modest traffic (estimate: low hundreds of monthly visits to 2-3 pages combined), not competitive #1 rankings, which are still 12+ months out for the harder terms [§1.2] .
- [] **8-12 real Google reviews**, at least 2-3 Clutch reviews live — realistic threshold to apply for a first small "Best of" style award (UpCity or a city/category Expertise.com listing) [§3.1] .
- [] **First podcast guest appearance or Lviv IT Arena-style speaking/community appearance secured** — aim for one mid-sized, niche-fit show rather than a top-tier one, using a concrete story (e.g., the preschool result) as the pitch hook [§3.2] .
- [] **2-3 total guest posts / backlink placements live** cumulative [§1.7] .
- [] **Social proof loop operational:** at least one new client's result becomes a testimonial/content piece within the same quarter it happens (not a 6-month-later retrofit) — signals the content engine has become routine, not a one-time push.
- [] **Revisit the "Vike" brand-collision tracking:** pull Search Console query data filtered for "vike"-containing queries — compare impressions vs. clicks/position to see whether the disambiguation strategy [§0] is working, and flag if a rename conversation is warranted (expected answer at this stage: too early to tell, keep monitoring).

Honest Q3 expectation: this is the quarter Vike starts looking like a legitimate, findable small agency to a skeptical Ireland/Netherlands prospect doing due diligence — a handful of reviews, a real (if modest) content library, one or two third-party mentions. It is not the quarter Vike ranks competitively for "performance marketing agency ireland" — that class of term realistically needs 12+ months minimum given the current zero-authority starting point, often longer.

Q4 (Months 10-12): Consolidate Into Premium Positioning

Theme: shift the narrative from "new agency proving itself" to "agency with a track record and transparent, credible proof" — premium positioning is earned through consistency here, not claimed through better copywriting.

Milestones

- [] **10-15+ real Google reviews, Clutch reviews established**, at least one award/ranking listing live (realistic: a city/category Expertise.com or UpCity listing, not a top-tier global "best agency" award — those take longer than 12 months for a solo, contract-free agency with this starting point) **[\$3.1]**.
- [] **Full content library in place:** all six service pages, pricing page, 8-10+ blog articles, 2-3 local niche pages, at least 2-3 client story pages — a genuine, if modest, resource that supports both SEO and sales conversations.
- [] **Cumulative backlink count in the 15-25 range** (directories + guest posts + client links + any press/podcast show-notes links) — realistic for a solo operator across 12 months, not hundreds **[\$1.7]**.
- [] **2+ podcast/guest content placements total**, at least one piece of genuine third-party press or community recognition (Lviv IT Cluster feature, a guest post on a recognized SMB/marketing site, etc.) **[\$3.2]**.
- [] **Social channels have a consistent, recognizable voice** — LinkedIn averaging real engagement (not just post volume) from the target ICPs, Instagram carrying a real backlog of UGC/client-proof content rather than placeholder posts **[\$2]**.
- [] **Re-evaluate pricing/positioning honestly:** with 12 months of real reviews and case studies, this is the point to consider whether the \$750 "Dominate" tier should become a genuine premium tier with a case-study-backed sales page, or whether a new top tier is warranted — a decision to make *with* evidence in hand, not before.
- [] **Reassess team/capacity honestly:** if the cofounder friend or UGC creator have become formally involved by this point, update all external copy (About page, LinkedIn, outreach) to reflect that accurately — continuing to represent Vike as solo when it no longer is would be as dishonest as overstating it earlier.

Honest Q12-month expectation: Vike Marketing at month 12 realistically looks like a small, credible, review-backed, contract-free agency with a real (if not yet dominant) presence in its niche local markets and early, genuine footholds in Ireland/Netherlands — not a "top-tier global performance marketing agency," which remains the stated long-term ambition and is realistically a multi-year outcome built on exactly this kind of compounding, honestly-paced work. The biggest risk to this timeline is not the strategy — it's founder capacity: 16 hrs/week solo, split across client delivery, outreach, and all of the above, is a genuinely tight budget, and this roadmap assumes some quarters will slip rather than assuming perfect execution throughout.

Cross-Quarter Tracking (what "working" looks like, measured honestly)

Metric	Q1 target	Q2 target	Q3 target	Q4 target
Site indexed	Yes (by end of Q1)	—	—	—
Google reviews (cumulative)	3-5	5-8	8-12	10-15+
Published SEO content pieces (cumulative)	4	7	10	12+
Backlinks (cumulative, estimate)	5-10	10-15	15-20	15-25
Podcast/guest/speaking placements (cumulative)	0	0-1	1-2	2+
Awards/directory recognitions (cumulative)	0	0-1 applied	1 live	1-2 live

All figures above are internal planning targets, not benchmarked against third-party data — they are the plan's own honest estimates of solo-founder throughput at 16 hrs/week, cross-checked against the realistic content/link volumes discussed in [06-growth-and-seo.md](#).